dismantling of infrastructure and restoration of land forms. In this manner, through discussion, we kept whittling away at the points of divergence in order to reach a mutually acceptable solution. The peak winter months were spent in consolidating our positions, improving surface connectivity and constructing modern habitat, including large sheds capable of garaging armour and an underground Advanced Dressing Station, capable of undertaking surgeries. This spurt in infrastructure development was a strategic signal that we were ready to hold on for as long as it took.

On 10 November, I had my bimonthly tête-à-tête with the PM. This followed the same pattern; first, a call scheduling the meeting, then another asking for the agenda. Fortunately, this time around, there were quite a few points to brief him about. I had gone as scheduled at 1030 hours, but the PM came in only about twenty minutes later. As soon as he entered, he apologized for the delay, saying he had got caught up in a flurry of calls, which I thought was very gracious of him. I have always felt that one of the qualities of a true leader is that you value the time of your subordinates as much as you value your own time. I started off by giving feedback on my visit to Nepal and the positive vibes it had created, followed by the situation in Eastern Ladakh and the progress of the talks. I brought to his notice how leaks to the media were jeopardizing the talks, with the PLA often retracting from what had been discussed, as they felt that we were trying to corner them through these motivated leaks. I highlighted the rapid improvement in infrastructure that had taken place, and how, because of the Emergency Powers that had been delegated to the Service HQ, we had been able to achieve in five months what would otherwise have taken five years. The situation in J & K and the LC was discussed and I brought out that ceasefire violations and terrorist actions

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